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How do design stories work? Exploring narrative forms of knowledge in HCI

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How do design stories work? Exploring narrative forms of knowledge in HCI

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Abstract

Design is storied, and stories are designed. While elements of stories have long been part of the field through methods like personas, scenarios and design fictions, there has been a recent surge of new approaches including fabulations, epics, memoirs, site-writing and design events. In this workshop we aim to understand how stories are built, what narrative traditions they draw from, how they co-constitute research processes and what kind of knowledge can emerge from them. Specifically, we will explore the role of storytelling in HCI, the craft of writing stories, relations between fiction, truth and knowledge and finally the risks, tensions and limitations of writing stories. We will outline an overview of this new wave of stories in HCI and what they are activating and advocating for, build a set of tips, tricks and advice for writing stories and keep track of ongoing issues and open questions for further research.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing**; • **Human computer interaction (HCI)**;

Keywords

Story, Stories, Narrative, Design Research, Relational knowledge

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1 Why a workshop on stories?

HCI researchers have long drawn on narrative forms for methods such as scenarios, design fictions, personas. More recently, HCI researchers have turned to a wider range of storytelling including fabulations [24], epics [6], memoirs [7], autospeculation [18], design events [5, 14, 14, 21, 22] , design stories [25], thickening [15] site-writing [11] and counterstories [3, 23] to name a few. These works indicate a shift towards a deeper engagement with stories in design and HCI; they emphasize the value of engaging with imagination as a way of knowing, recognize the importance of the written word in engaging with personal/autobiographical memory and utilize the power of shifting points of view.

However, HCI researchers have yet to unpack or attend to how stories build meaning and function as research. For example, there is room to explore, elements of plot, characters, narrative arcs [2], but also voice, rhythm, tone and other presentational qualities, as well as what narrative traditions stories draw from, and how they co-constitute processes of design. Understanding these aspects of stories would help us to use them more actively and acutely in HCI. Beyond dissemination of results, we argue that stories can be used as active inquiry. While potentially meaningful across all elements of design, we particularly see an emerging interest around storytelling in research on more-than-human design, feminist HCI, and auto-genres. For example, how might storytelling enable us to bring forward the agencies of or entanglements with nonhumans? Who is speaking in the stories, and whose voices can be amplified more? How do we narrate first-person research? How might stories strengthen efforts to foreground processes of research-through-design, including twists, turns and failures?

In this workshop, we will explore a variety of narratives as forms of knowledge. We invite HCI researchers to submit a story and to reflect on the following questions:

- What is the relation between fact and fable in a story? What "data" is or can be at the start of stories? For example, (auto)ethnographic observations, design events, other?
- How do we build stories? How can we explore character building, perspective taking, temporalities, and narrative strategies?
- What form can stories take? What grammar and language do we use for what (verbs/nouns for nonhumans, and the agency it implies, for example)?
- What makes a "good" story? How might we publish and review them? Where does the story go? What would it take to submit a story to CHI?
- What type of knowledge emerges from design stories?
- Much like design research, there is a craft to writing and making stories. How can the process of writing be translated into findings?
- How do design stories capture elements of embodied or tacit practice that are obscured with other forms of academic reporting?
- What are the relations and tensions between stories, fiction, truth, memory, and knowledge?
- How might different knowledge be embodied and performed through stories?

2 The story so far

2.1 Tales of humans and machines

Design has a long history of storytelling, also within HCI. For example, researchers have used methods such as personas, storyboards and scenarios to create thick descriptions of how designed technologies may end up in people's life. Design fiction draws on science fiction to envision future scenarios, including utopic and dystopic possibilities. Overall, these forms of storytelling use narrative power of stories to put technologies in context, to see how they would fit or create a particular world. Yet, these approaches have also been critiqued for presenting humans as mere characters in service of the technology, for presenting solutionist and techno-idealistic visions and for repeating similar forms of plot that can be limiting in understanding the wider implications of technologies in our lifeworlds.

HCI is changing: it is increasingly drawing on philosophical and theoretical works that see the world as entangled, porous and inherently relational. This comes with many challenges that require new ways of working: including the way we write up, disseminate and narrate research. In response, more diverse forms of storytelling are emerging from design communities that are more explorative with writing form, tone and vocabulary. For example, Devendorf et. al. draw on auto-theory in their design memoirs to explore what can be found in forms of documentation that have *"elastic connections to the truth"* [7]. Similarly, Sondergaard, Campo Woytuk et al build on Haraway to propose design fabulations [24]. Within first-person perspectives, there have been ongoing calls for transparent narration [4].

We are interested in bringing together these newer forms of narrative and storytelling that have been emerging from design to understand how they can work methodologically. Stories, as forms of knowledge, also have a long history in non-western ways of being and knowing and are tools of worldbuilding and world reconfiguring. Storytelling traditions like afrofuturism have recently been brought into speculation in HCI [3], and recent research on black feminist technoscience traditions argues these theoretical traditions can "destabilize the single story of design" in HCI [22]. These examples probe storytelling can upend world building, power relations, and even design praxis. Storytelling can open doors to a world of many worlds.

2.2 Relational Knowing Through Storytelling

In everyday life, people often use stories to make sense of the world around them. Sometimes, these stories are collectively constructed: imaginaries shared by groups of people that can in turn shape how we envision presents, pasts and futures [13]. Others have argued that people are essentially a storytelling species, emphasizing the connections between narrative and identity [19, 26]. Within literary circles, there is growing attention to the interplay between autobiographical narrative and theory [1, 8, 10, 20]. Stories, fables, myths and epics are also central to indigenous ways of knowing and hold valuable intergenerational knowledge of worldviews and relations [16, 17]. Taken together, these storytellers show us there is no single story of any event, and that rearranging or fabulating story elements can generate new points of view, representations and imaginations. Furthermore, storytelling and narrative as forms

of knowledge are resonant themes in relational theories that are increasingly finding footing in HCI. For example, Ingold has long argued for writing and storytelling as a unique way for humans to engage with the more-than-human world [12]. He positions stories as a multi-interpretable, relational form of knowledge that one can grow into, as opposed to the rigid boundaries of narration through classifications. In a classification, *"every element is slotted into place on the basis of intrinsic characteristics"* [12:160]. Stories allow for a messier, more connected, and mesh-worked type of knowledge: "*we can understand the nature of things only by attending to their relations, or in other words, by telling their stories"* [12:160]. Ingold further suggests that storytelling is a peculiarly human ability to weave together different temporalities. Donna Haraway similarly emphasized the relational importance of storytelling and applied her speculative fabulation in her Camille stories: vignettes spanning five generations of living on earth as syms and critters, where human newborns are assigned to a species on earth (in Camille's case, a butterfly) to live in explicit symbioses [9]. Drawing from these works, we want to position stories in HCI as a particular form of relational knowledge and investigate what it might take to make it more central.

3 Workshop goals and anticipated outcomes

Stories have a particular ability to synthesize, disseminate and be generative of situated and relational knowledge. From this perspective, we see opportunities to revisit, reconsider and reframe uses of narrative within this relational move of HCI. In this workshop, we will explore the spectrum of storytelling in research from narrative to more experimental. Particularly, we are interested in understanding better the ability of HCI researchers themselves as storytellers, for example, in approaches such as autofiction and autospeculation. We also see opportunities for feminist HCI, more-than-human design, autobiographical design and more, given their commitment to situated knowledge and relational thought. We will do so across three themes.

The Role of Storytelling in HCI Research: exploring the increasing use of diverse narrative forms (e.g., fabulations, design fictions, memoirs) in HCI and design, emphasizing the role of imagination and storytelling as a method of inquiry rather than just a medium for dissemination, broadening how stories can be used not just to communicate findings but also as a method for exploring complex research topics, such as more-than-human design, feminist HCI, and auto-genres. We will explore the potential of storytelling for highlighting entanglements with nonhumans and other marginalized perspectives.

The Craft of Story Writing in Design Research: understanding on how stories are built in terms of elements like plot, characters, and narrative arcs, as well as presentational qualities like voice, tone, and rhythm. It raises questions about how storytelling can contribute to research processes and design. Discussing the skills, sensibilities and craftsmanship involved in writing stories and how it intersects with design research, raising questions about how the process of writing can be transformed into meaningful research findings.

Fiction, Truth, and Knowledge in Storytelling: investigating the relationship between fiction, truth, memory, and knowledge in storytelling, examining how these elements create tensions and synergies in the production of research narratives. We will also explore the challenges of evaluating and publishing design stories in academic venues like CHI.

Risks, Tensions, Issues and Limitations of Story Writing: surfacing potential risks for HCI researchers taking up storytelling. In particular, we will examine the importance and impact of positionality when writing, address the risk of overexposing oneself when writing for a public (even in fiction), and question the limitations of amateur writing (for researchers who feel inexperienced with crafting stories).

Through these themes, we will outline an overview of this new wave of stories in HCI and what they are good for, build a set of tips, tricks and advice for writing stories and keep track of ongoing issues and open questions for further research.

4 Storytellers

Doenja Oogjes (she/her) is a design researcher focusing on the relations between design and more-than-human worlds. She is an Assistant Professor at the department of Industrial Design at Eindhoven University of Technology. Informed by feminist posthumanism, she develops design strategies, crafts research products and conducts long-term field studies. She aims to strengthen the imaginative and speculative potential of design by developing vocabularies and tools.

Heidi Biggs (they/she) is a design researcher and Assistant Professor at the Georgia Institute of Technology's School of Literature, Media, and Communication. Their research on environmental sustainability explores the way certain narratives of progress, success, innovation, and binary orientations entangle us into certain material orientations and relationships. Their research seeks the unbinding and reframing said narratives through design explorations that are tangible, embodied, and situated, in hopes of finding more sustainable orientations and paths forward.

Audrey Desjardins (she/her) is a design researcher who speculatively and critically examines how people live with technology and reimagines the familiar co-existence of humans and things. She is an associate professor in interaction design in the School of Art + Art History + Design at the University of Washington. Her recent projects touch on ways to inquire and reclaim personal data through crafting, sonifying, fictionalizing, and materializing ways of living with that data. She designs to articulate questions, to propose alternatives and to provoke reflection.

Nadia Campo Woytuk (she/they) is a PhD student in Interaction Design at KTH Royal Institute of Technology in Stockholm, Sweden, exploring critical feminist design of technologies for the intimate body and the social and environmental ecologies it entangles. Her PhD work draws from feminist posthumanities to explore how to design for experiences of menstruation, fertility, sexual and reproductive health in ways that uplift embodied, sensory and material knowledge. Nadia is interested in fabrication with textiles and biomaterials, and brings together participatory and speculative approaches in her research.

Sylvia Janicki (she/her) is a design researcher exploring how disability perspectives can contribute to alternative environmental relations and new ways of designing with technologies. She is

a PhD candidate in Digital Media at Georgia Tech. Her research brings together disability theory and more-than-human scholarship to reimagine data and sensing practices through creative, material scholarship, drawing heavily from first-person narratives of chronic illness. Her work seeks to build alliances between disability and ecological justice.

Karey Helms (she/her) is a design researcher interested in situations where technology is often considered out of place, such as intimate settings of care or outdoor ecologies. She explores how "being human" is engaged with practically, conceptually, performatively, and/or materially. She is a postdoctoral researcher at Stockholm University and an associate professor at Umeå Institute of Design.

Kristina Andersen (she/her) is a design researcher currently working on how we may reperform and remake as a strategy to consider memories and uncertainty. She is an associate professor of Industrial Design of the Eindhoven University of Technology. Her work is situated in digital craftsmanship in the context of material practices of fiber-based things. She is especially interested in ephemeral archives and how they might point towards physical manifestations of new and different outcomes.

Laura Devendorf (she/her) is a design researcher currently working on methods of archiving and communicating craft knowledge between communities of weavers and engineers. She is an assistant professor of Information Science and ATLAS Institute fellow at the University of Colorado Boulder. She also directs the Unstable Design Lab, where she works with students to design interventions with technology that are characterized by reflection, negotiation, and humility.

Marie Louise Juul Søndergaard (she/her) is a designer and researcher exploring feminist design of technologies for human and environmental health. She is curious about how the materiality of human bodies relates with ecologies, and uses research-through-design, participation of communities and speculative storytelling to design for social and environmental justice. She has a PhD in Interaction Design from Aarhus University in Denmark and has been a postdoc at KTH Royal Institute of Technology in Sweden and the Oslo School of Architecture and Design in Norway, where she researched somatic approaches in design and more-than-human design.

Li Jönsson (she/her) is Senior Lecturer in Design at the School of Arts and Communication at Malmö University. Her work focuses on STS, feminist techno-science, environmental participation and experimental design research. She is currently immersed in questioning and practices concerning design as memory making and embodied prefiguration. She currently co-organises the following research projects: Design after Progress: Reimagining Design Histories and Futures.

5 Website

The website (www.hcidesignstories.com) will be used before and after the workshop as a place to promote the workshop and to share the Call for Participation (CfP). The authors will continue to maintain the website after the workshop.

6 Pre-workshop plan

Our goal is to reach a broad audience interested in developing stories as methodology in HCI. The CHI community will be invited to submit a **position story,** consisting of a 1 page story and 1 page of positioning that includes a statement of how the story is relevant to the HCI community, reflection on what type of knowledge is engaged with and any open questions the authors may have about the intentions, crafting and/or hesitations and struggles with their story. The story can be presented as a finished piece or a draft that they wish to develop further in the workshop. We encourage submissions that are experimental with form, tone, rhythms of storytelling. The submission can also include visuals, such as photos, illustrations and other imagery, though we do emphasize the importance of written text. We will highlight in the CFP and website that the selection criteria are (1) the storytelling is central to the creation of the submission (2) the submission must be created and used within a research framework and with research goals (3) the authors must speak to the positioning of storytelling and connections to the workshop goals. Submissions will be accepted in 2-4 page documents formatted using the ACM CHI 2024 template. We will publicize the workshop and distribute the CFP via relevant mailing lists, social media outlets, as well as personal networks in various research communities (e.g. more-than-human design, feminist HCI, digital fabrication, IoT and data, soma design, craft and material-led practices). We will create a website to advertise the workshop through which we will communicate with accepted participants and disseminate the work pre- and post-workshop. The workshop papers will be submitted through the website to be reviewed by the organizers. Accepted submissions will be uploaded to the website for the participants to engage with before and after the event of the workshop. We aim to recruit 20-30 participants.

7 Accommodating asynchronous storytelling

This workshop will take place in a hybrid format. While we expect most participants to attend in person, remote participation will also be supported. For those joining remotely, we will use our institution's Zoom link. Digital collaboration tools like Miro and Google Docs will be the primary means of documenting activities, ensuring both in-person and remote attendees can easily engage and interact. Any in-person tasks (such as whiteboarding or paper prototyping) will be recorded via webcam and streamed on Zoom. Links to shared documents will be provided in advance so that participants who are unable to join in real-time can review and catch up at their own pace. Photos of in-person synchronous activities will also be shared in the documents for participants to view and leave comments on afterward.

We will have several organizers dedicated to managing the hybrid experience. These organizers are experienced in running and facilitating workshops in both hybrid and online formats, and they have participated in several virtual conferences and workshops.

8 Workshop structure

This workshop will focus on the intersections between storytelling, writing, and design critique in the context of HCI. Participants will engage in collaborative writing exercises, group discussions, and

critiques of each other's stories. The goal is to deepen our understanding of narrative techniques and how storytelling can function as both a method of inquiry and a form of research dissemination in design.

Participants will work in small groups to read, critique, and discuss stories, followed by reflective writing sessions prompted by specific narrative challenges. Additionally, participants are invited to take part in a "Book-Exchange" activity, exchanging books with personal notes on why they found the book meaningful.

- 9:00 - 9:30. Welcome & Introduction. Overview of workshop goals, schedule, and group formation.
- 10:00 - 11:00. Story sharing & Group Discussions. Small groups (4-5 people) discuss and reflect with each other's stories. The focus will be on narrative techniques and storytelling approaches.
- 11:00 - 12:00. Reflection on The Role of Storytelling. As a group, reflect on story writing and any questions that have come up. What was challenging in coming up with the stories? What was the connection between truth and fiction? Finally, consider what type of knowledge is being made possible through these stories?
- 12:00 - 13:30. Lunch Break (book trade / traveling library). Optional: participants are invited to bring books to exchange, leaving a personal note on why they like the book.
- 13:30 - 14:30. The Craft of Story Writing. 10-minute writing sessions with prompts like "write from a new perspective," "use only short sentences," "replace nouns with verbs," and "elongate an event." Participants post their favorite sentences to a shared document. Return to open questions from earlier discussions. Share experiences from the writing session
- 14:30 - 15:00. Fiction, Truth, and Knowledge in Storytelling. Writing sessions in which participants will be asked to think of a personal experience where the line between fiction and truth felt blurred. Write a short, fictionalized version of a true story from your life, slightly altering details to explore how the narrative feels. Take a known fictional story (book, movie, etc.) and reflect on how elements of it feel like they could be "true" in your own life or research.
- 15:00 - 15:30. Break (book trade / traveling library). Continuation of the lunch break activity.
- 16:00 - 16:30. Risks, Tensions, Issues and Limitations of story writing. Full group discussion on tensions, issues and limitations that have arisen during the story writing and the workshop. What are the ethical or professional risks of using storytelling in research? What conflicts or dilemmas arise when storytelling is used in research (e.g., subjectivity vs. objectivity)? What practical or methodological issues might surface in story-based research? Where does storytelling fall short in research? What knowledge or insights might it fail to capture?
- 16:30 - 17:00. Closing Remarks & Next Steps. Summarize key takeaways from the workshop, discuss potential collaborations or follow-up activities.

9 Post-workshop plans

After the workshop, pictures and digital records from group activities and discussions will be posted to the workshop website. The discussions and outputs of the workshop will be communicated to the broader HCI community via the publication of a workshop report or an ACM Interactions article in which the organizers will summarize outcomes from the workshops and provide suggested paths to make storytelling more central in HCI. Finally, the workshop will kick-off a collaborative reading list and book-exchange of non-theory books that have inspired the participants and organizers. The idea is to each bring a book that will be passed on to another participant, and to continue doing so within a growing community during ACM conferences. Participating in the book exchange is entirely voluntary. The travelling library and reading list will be organized and published on the website.

10 Call for participation

Design is storied, and stories are designed. Do you make use of storytelling in your research? How do stories work in design in HCI? What types of knowledge can stories produce? Researchers have long used narrative methods such as scenarios, design fictions, and personas. Recently, there has been a broader turn towards storytelling forms like fabulations, epics, memoirs, autospeculation, design events, site-writing, and counterstories. This workshop aims to explore the growing role of stories in HCI and design, emphasizing storytelling as an active method of inquiry rather than just a tool for dissemination. **Workshop Goals:** We will focus on the role of storytelling in design and HCI, the craft of storytelling, relations between fiction, truth, and knowledge and finally the risk, tensions and limitations of using stories in HCI. Through writing exercises and discussions participants will reflect on how storytelling techniques (plot, character, voice, etc.) can reveal new knowledge in areas such as more-than-human design, feminist HCI, and auto-genres. We invite participants to submit a **1-2 page story** along with a **1-page reflection** positioning the story in relation to HCI (submission Format: 2-4 pages following the ACM CHI 2024 template). The story can be a draft or finished piece and may include visuals, though we encourage a focus on written text. We encourage experimental storytelling formats and submissions that reflect on the process and challenges of writing within a research context.

More information is available on www.hcidesignstories.com. The deadline for submissions is February 13, 2025.

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